MAKE IT DO · FREE SHEET

What things cost the year you were born

1974

IN 1974	THE RECORD	TODAY	IN OUR HOUSE
A gallon of gas regular, with taxes	53¢	**$3.26** regular unleaded	
A stamp for a letter first-class, first ounce	10¢	**82¢** Forever stamp	
A new house median price of new homes sold	$35,900	—	
An hour's pay at the federal minimum from May 1, 1974	$2.00	**$7.25** federal minimum since 2009	

The government's national table of food prices we use (Historical Statistics of the United States, series E 187-202) ends in 1970, so this year shows gas, stamps, pay and housing only.

THE NAMES IN THE HOSPITAL NURSERY, 1974

Girls: Jennifer, Amy, Michelle, Heather, Angela. **Boys:** Michael, Jason, Christopher, David, James.

One dollar in 1974 buys about what **$6.53** buys today (consumer price index, 2025 average). The last column is yours: write in what it cost in your house.

Where every number comes from. U.S. Energy Information Administration, Annual Energy Review 2011 (DOE/EIA-0384(2011)), Table 5.24 Retail Motor Gasoline and On-Highway Diesel Fuel Prices, Leaded Regular gasoline, U.S. city average, Nominal, AER 2011 Table 5.24 web/spreadsheet version (all years); printed p. 173 shows selected years only; United States Postal Service,

From the Make It Do film *Everyday Life in 1950s America, in Real Color Film*

Historian, "Rates for Domestic Letters Since 1863" (September 2021), Table "Postage in Cents, per Ounce" (effective dates), p. 1 (single-page PDF); U.S. Census Bureau and U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development, Survey of Construction (New Residential Sales): Sales Price of New Privately-Owned Houses Sold, Annual, United States, Median sales price, sheet "Annual", row 1974; U.S. Department of Labor, Wage and Hour Division, History of Federal Minimum Wage Rates Under the Fair Labor Standards Act, 1938-2009 (1938 Act column). Today: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics average prices, 2025 average; USPS 2026.